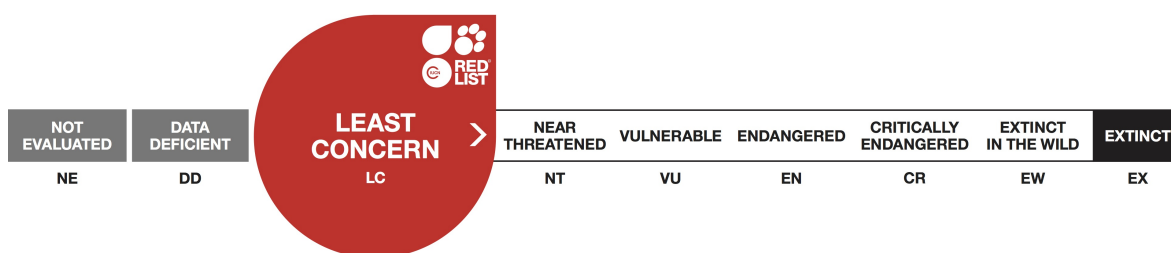


Bassariscus astutus, Ringtail

Assessment by: Reid, F., Schipper, J. & Timm, R.



View on www.iucnredlist.org

Citation: Reid, F., Schipper, J. & Timm, R. 2016. *Bassariscus astutus*. The IUCN Red List of Threatened Species 2016: e.T41680A45215881. <http://dx.doi.org/10.2305/IUCN.UK.2016-1.RLTS.T41680A45215881.en>

Copyright: © 2016 International Union for Conservation of Nature and Natural Resources

Reproduction of this publication for educational or other non-commercial purposes is authorized without prior written permission from the copyright holder provided the source is fully acknowledged.

Reproduction of this publication for resale, reposting or other commercial purposes is prohibited without prior written permission from the copyright holder. For further details see [Terms of Use](#).

The IUCN Red List of Threatened Species™ is produced and managed by the [IUCN Global Species Programme](#), the [IUCN Species Survival Commission \(SSC\)](#) and [The IUCN Red List Partnership](#). The IUCN Red List Partners are: [BirdLife International](#); [Botanic Gardens Conservation International](#); [Conservation International](#); [Microsoft](#); [NatureServe](#); [Royal Botanic Gardens, Kew](#); [Sapienza University of Rome](#); [Texas A&M University](#); [Wildscreen](#); and [Zoological Society of London](#).

If you see any errors or have any questions or suggestions on what is shown in this document, please provide us with [feedback](#) so that we can correct or extend the information provided.

Taxonomy

Kingdom	Phylum	Class	Order	Family
Animalia	Chordata	Mammalia	Carnivora	Procyonidae

Taxon Name: *Bassariscus astutus* (Lichtenstein, 1830)

Synonym(s):

- *Bassariscus astutus* Lichtenstein, 1830

Common Name(s):

- English: Ringtail

Taxonomic Notes:

The genus *Bassariscus*, which comprises only two species, is regarded together with *Bassaricyon* as one of the most primitive procyonid genera (Wozencraft 1989). It is also one of only two procyonid genera not confounded with known taxonomic problems.

Assessment Information

Red List Category & Criteria: Least Concern [ver 3.1](#)

Year Published: 2016

Date Assessed: March 1, 2015

Justification:

This Ringtail is listed as Least Concern because it is common and widely distributed from central USA to northern Mexico, and adapts well to disturbed areas (Barja and List 2006).

Previously Published Red List Assessments

2008 – Least Concern (LC) – <http://dx.doi.org/10.2305/IUCN.UK.2008.RLTS.T41680A10508712.en>

1996 – Lower Risk/least concern (LR/lc)

Geographic Range

Range Description:

The Ringtail is widely distributed in Mexico and across the United States of America from southern Oregon and California through the south-western states to Texas (Hall 1981, Poglayen-Neuwall and Toweill 1988). In Mexico, its distribution is from the desert region of the Baja California peninsula to Oaxaca. Three islands in the Gulf of California are included in its distribution: Tiburón, Espíritu Santo, and San José (Lawlor 1983). The species is usually distributed from sea level to 1,400 m a.s.l. with records at 2,000 and 2900 m a.s.l. (Poglayen-Neuwall and Toweill 1988).

Country Occurrence:

Native: Mexico; United States

Distribution Map

Bassariscus astutus

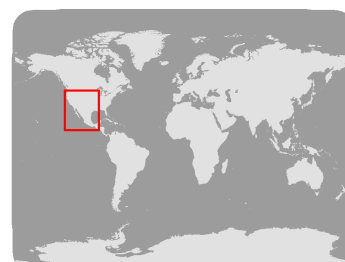


Range

Extant (resident)

Compiled by:

IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature)



The boundaries and names shown and the designations used on this map do not imply any official endorsement, acceptance or opinion by IUCN.



Population

Found always in low densities and considered not abundant. Densities reported for Ringtail vary from 10.5 to 20.5 individuals/km² (Belluomini 1983, Belluomini and Trapp 1984), 7 to 20 individuals/km² (Lacy 1983) and 2.2 to 4.2/km² (Toweill and Teer 1980) to 0.08 to 2.3 individuals/km² (Grinnell *et al.* 1937) and 1.5 to 2.9 individuals/km² (Trapp 1973, 1978).

Current Population Trend: Unknown

Habitat and Ecology (see Appendix for additional information)

The Ringtail occurs in a variety of habitats: semi-arid oak forests (*Quercus*), Pinyon Pine (*Pinus edulis*) or juniper (*Juniperus*) woodland, montane conifer forests, chaparral, desert, dry tropical habitats and rocky or cliff areas (Poglayen-Neuwall and Toweill 1988). It adapts well to disturbed areas and is frequently found in human habitation (Barja and List 2006). Reports on home range include 5.0 to 13.8 ha for four individuals (Lacy 1983), 43.4 ha (35 and 51.7 ha) for two males and 20.3 ha (15.7 to 27.7 ha) for three females (Toweill and Teer 1980) and 136 ha (49 to 233) for nine individuals. Ringtail is a nocturnal carnivore with some crepuscular activity and is solitary, except for the breeding season (Toweill and Toweill 1978, Poglayen-Neuwall and Toweill 1988). It breeds at the end of February and gives birth in May (Poglayen-Neuwall and Poglayen-Neuwall 1980). It eats rodents, insects, birds, and a good amount of fruit (Trapp 1978, Aranda 2000).

Systems: Terrestrial

Use and Trade

For information on use and trade, see under Threats.

Threats (see Appendix for additional information)

The Ringtail is legally trapped for fur in the states of Arizona, New Mexico, Colorado, and Texas (USA), where it is also caught incidentally in traps set for valuable fur-bearers such as foxes (Canidae) and raccoons *Procyon*. In recent years about 4,000 have been taken annually in Arizona, and about 1,000 in New Mexico. In Texas 45,000~50,000 Ringtails were trapped each year from 1979 to 1985. As with raccoons, the number of Ringtails trapped for fur has declined since a peak in 1979, when approximately 135,000 pelts were sold. Ringtail fur is of poor quality (thin, non-durable, and subject to fading), and pelts have usually sold for less than US\$5 each although they have brought as much as US\$12. The justification for trapping Ringtails for fur is weak, especially because in none of the states where trapping is legal is there sufficient knowledge of population levels and trends on which to base valid harvest regulations (Glatston 1994). Threats to the Ringtail include also automobiles (Glatston 1994).

Conservation Actions (see Appendix for additional information)

The Ringtail occurs in a number of protected areas.

Credits

Assessor(s): Reid, F., Schipper, J. & Timm, R.

Reviewer(s): Duckworth, J.W.

Bibliography

- Aranda, M. 2000. *Huellas y Otros Rastros de Los Mamíferos Grandes y Medianos de México*. Comisión Nacional para el Conocimiento y Uso de la Biodiversidad, Mexico City, Mexico.
- Barja, I. and List, R. 2006. Faecal marking behaviour in ringtails (*Bassariscus astutus*) during the non-breeding period: Spatial characteristics of latrines and single faeces. *Chemoecology* 16: 219-222.
- Belluomini, L. 1983. Ringtail (*Bassariscus astutus*) distribution and abundance in the Central Valley of California. California State University.
- Belluomini, L. and Trapp, G. 1984. Ringtail distribution and abundance in the Central Valley of California. *California riparian system; ecology, conservation, and productive management*, pp. 1035 pp.. University of California Press, Berkeley, CA, USA.
- Glatston, A.R. 1994. *The Red Panda, Olingos, Coatis, Raccoons, and their Relatives. Status Survey and Conservation Action Plan for Procyonids and Ailurids*. IUCN/SSC Mustelid, Viverrid and Procyonid Specialist Group, Gland, Switzerland.
- Grinnell, J., Dixon, J.S. and Linsdale, J.M. 1937. *Fur-bearing Mammals of California*. University of California Press, Berkeley, California, USA.
- Hall, E.R. 1981. *The Mammals of North America*. John Wiley and Sons, New York, USA.
- IUCN. 2016. The IUCN Red List of Threatened Species. Version 2016-1. Available at: www.iucnredlist.org. (Accessed: 30 June 2016).
- Lacy, M. 1983. Home range size, intraspecific spacing and habitat preference of Ringtails (*Bassariscus astutus*) in a riparian forest in California. University of California.
- Lawlor, T. 1983. The Mammals. In: T.J. Cade and M.L. Cody (eds), *Island Biogeography in the Sea of Cortéz*, pp. 508. University of California Press, Berkeley, California, USA.
- Poglayen-Neuwall, I. 1980. Gestation period and parturition on the Ringtail *Bassariscus astutus* (Lichtenstein, 1830). *Zeitschrift für Säugetierkunde* 45: 73-81.
- Poglayen-Neuwall, I. and Poglayen-Neuwall, I. 1980. Gestation period and parturition of the Ringtail *Bassariscus astutus* (Liechtenstein, 1830). *Zeitschrift für Säugetierkunde* 45: 73-81.
- Poglayen-Neuwall, I. and Toweill, D. E. 1988. *Bassariscus astutus*. *Mammalian Species* 327: 1-8.
- Toweill, D. and Teer, J. 1980. Home range and den habits of Texas Ringtails (*Bassariscus astutus javus*). In: J.A. Chapman and D. Pursley (eds), *Proceedings of the worldwide furbearers conference*, pp. 2059 pp.. Frostburg, Maryland, USA.
- Toweill, D.E. and Toweill, D.B. 1978. Growth and development of captive Ringtails (*Bassariscus astutus flavus*). *Carnivore* 1: 46-53.
- Trapp, G. R. 1973. Comparative behavioral ecology of two southwestern Utah carnivores: *Bassariscus astutus* and *Urocyon cinereogenteus*. Thesis, University of Wisconsin.
- Trapp, G. R. 1978. Comparative behavioral ecology of the Ringtail and Gray Fox in southwestern Utah. *Carnivore* 1: 3-32.
- Wozencraft, W. C. 1989. Classification of the recent carnivora. In: L. Gittleman (ed.), *Carnivore Behaviour, Ecology and Evolution*, pp. 569-594. Chapman & Hall, London, UK.

Citation

Reid, F., Schipper, J. & Timm, R. 2016. *Bassariscus astutus*. *The IUCN Red List of Threatened Species 2016*: e.T41680A45215881. <http://dx.doi.org/10.2305/IUCN.UK.2016-1.RLTS.T41680A45215881.en>

Disclaimer

To make use of this information, please check the [Terms of Use](#).

External Resources

For [Images and External Links to Additional Information](#), please see the Red List website.

Appendix

Habitats

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Habitat	Season	Suitability	Major Importance?
1. Forest -> 1.5. Forest - Subtropical/Tropical Dry	-	Suitable	Yes
1. Forest -> 1.6. Forest - Subtropical/Tropical Moist Lowland	-	Suitable	Yes
1. Forest -> 1.9. Forest - Subtropical/Tropical Moist Montane	-	Suitable	Yes
3. Shrubland -> 3.5. Shrubland - Subtropical/Tropical Dry	-	Suitable	Yes
3. Shrubland -> 3.7. Shrubland - Subtropical/Tropical High Altitude	-	Suitable	Yes
3. Shrubland -> 3.8. Shrubland - Mediterranean-type Shrubby Vegetation	-	Suitable	Yes
4. Grassland -> 4.5. Grassland - Subtropical/Tropical Dry	-	Suitable	Yes
4. Grassland -> 4.7. Grassland - Subtropical/Tropical High Altitude	-	Suitable	Yes
0. Root -> 6. Rocky areas (eg. inland cliffs, mountain peaks)	-	Suitable	Yes
14. Artificial/Terrestrial -> 14.5. Artificial/Terrestrial - Urban Areas	-	Marginal	-

Threats

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Threat	Timing	Scope	Severity	Impact Score
4. Transportation & service corridors -> 4.1. Roads & railroads	Ongoing	-	-	-
	Stresses:	2. Species Stresses -> 2.1. Species mortality		
5. Biological resource use -> 5.1. Hunting & trapping terrestrial animals -> 5.1.1. Intentional use (species is the target)	Ongoing	-	-	-
	Stresses:	2. Species Stresses -> 2.1. Species mortality		
5. Biological resource use -> 5.1. Hunting & trapping terrestrial animals -> 5.1.2. Unintentional effects (species is not the target)	Ongoing	-	-	-
	Stresses:	2. Species Stresses -> 2.1. Species mortality		

Conservation Actions in Place

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Conservation Actions in Place
In-Place Land/Water Protection and Management

Conservation Actions in Place
Occur in at least one PA: Yes

Research Needed

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Research Needed
3. Monitoring -> 3.1. Population trends

Additional Data Fields

Distribution
Lower elevation limit (m): 0
Upper elevation limit (m): 2900
Population
Population severely fragmented: No
Habitats and Ecology
Generation Length (years): 5.7

The IUCN Red List Partnership



The IUCN Red List of Threatened Species™ is produced and managed by the [IUCN Global Species Programme](#), the [IUCN Species Survival Commission \(SSC\)](#) and [The IUCN Red List Partnership](#).

The IUCN Red List Partners are: [BirdLife International](#); [Botanic Gardens Conservation International](#); [Conservation International](#); [Microsoft](#); [NatureServe](#); [Royal Botanic Gardens, Kew](#); [Sapienza University of Rome](#); [Texas A&M University](#); [Wildscreen](#); and [Zoological Society of London](#).